Significance assessment

The striking spectacle of hundreds of dolmens and tumuli, forming the characteristic cultural landscape, is the most prominent and conspicuous archaeological element of the Korazim Plateau. The Korazim dolmen field is the largest of its kind west of the Jordan River and one of the densest megalithic burial fields in the world. Within it, the unique and well-preserved Tuba dolmen field stands out (Fig.63).

Each dolmen is a product of an engineering construction effort that attests to a developed social organization, a sophisticated culture, and high technological knowledge and abilities, sometimes exaggeratedly compared to those of the pyramid builders in Egypt. The first basalt dolmen discovered in Israel was found in this field, documented as early as 1877. This discovery sparked ongoing research into this culture. These burial structures they left behind provide us with the most information about this culture. The enigmatic relics are all that remain of a civilization that sanctified its dead with monumental structures unknown in the area at any other historical period.

Since the discovery of dolmens in the Levant, there has been debate about their dating, and much remains unknown about the people who invested so much of their limited resources into the construction of megalithic tombs, especially compared with their assumed modest way of life. Future research may provide insights into this enigmatic phenomenon, enhancing our understanding of one of the most interesting phenomena in the archaeology of the Levant.

Figure 63: Aerial view of a dolmen from the Tuba-Zangariyye field and its surrounding (Photo taken by A. Kleiner, 2019)

The monumental remains stand almost as they were built about 4,400 years ago, creating a unique landscape known since biblical times, until recent times when the Bedouin Zangariyye tribes grazed their flocks in the area. Sadly, over the past 150 years, dozens of dolmens in the area have been damaged and destroyed due to development activities. Today, after extensive destruction, this dolmen field is a rare and almost the last remnant of this cultural landscape.

Results/ outcomes

The findings of the survey and evaluation were presented to the planners of the Ministry of Housing during a field visit. The result was a compromise in which the IAA was asked to redefine the areas for preservation and development in a manner that preserves the greatest number of dolmens and enables the development of the rest of the area. Based on the significance assessment, conservation principles have been at the forefront of planning efforts for the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field. These principles include preserving the dolmens as part of the megalithic landscape in an open and connected area; minimizing the impact of infrastructure and roads on the concentration of dolmens; preserving prominent individual dolmens; and incorporating dolmens into the planning of public buildings and tourism land use. Efforts have also been made to ensure that development works do not damage or cover the remaining dolmens. These principles were integrated in recent planning versions, and it remains to be seen how they will be implemented in the final plan and in subsequent detailed planning stages.

The case study illustrates a gradual shift in the IAA's practice from relying primarily on the Antiquities Law, which has proven insufficient for the effective protection and preservation of archaeological heritage, to integrating the site into the development plan. Other current ARM principles that emphasize community participation are another challenge for the future.

Acknowledgements

The authors would like to thank Jon Seligman for his thoughtful comments on the case study.